

Facing an amputation? Ask for a time out first.

Before a toe, foot, or leg is removed, your care team should check the blood flow in your legs. In the U.S., up to half of the people who have an amputation never get that check.



WHAT IS A VASCULAR TEST?

It is a check of how well blood is flowing to your legs and feet. The most common one, the **ankle-brachial index (ABI)**, compares the blood pressure at your ankle with the blood pressure in your arm. It is quick and does not hurt. Your team may also use an ultrasound of the leg arteries, toe pressures, or an imaging scan.

WHY IT MATTERS

Poor blood flow is one of the most common reasons a wound will not heal. If blood flow can be improved, a vascular specialist may be able to **save the limb or make a smaller surgery possible**. You cannot know your options until the test is done.

“The final decision regarding the need for amputation should be based on objective findings, not subjective opinion.”

THE SAVE A LEG, SAVE A LIFE FOUNDATION

Questions to ask your care team

- ☐ Have I had a test of the blood flow in my legs?
- ☐ What did the results show, and has a vascular specialist reviewed them?
- ☐ Is there a procedure that could improve the blood flow to my leg or foot?
- ☐ Are there other options to try before an amputation?
- ☐ Can I get a second opinion from a vascular or limb preservation specialist?

You have the right to a second opinion.

Bring this sheet to your next appointment, or share it with a loved one.



Learn more: thesalsal.org/toba

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